

game but because of viewership. With the rise of T20s, viewership has gone down so much for other formats. I fear that maybe in another three decades, there won't be any Test cricket, and there will only be T20s and T10s. Test cricket has survived for more than 100 years; now the question is: can it survive for another 100 years? We don't know.

Is there an overdose of cricket that's affecting the viewership?

Yeah, definitely. Too much cricket also puts off the spectators. For instance, if too many films are released every other day, people won't see them. Whereas, if one good film is released every three or four months, there will still be some sort of interest among the audience. Similarly, in cricket, when you have matches every day, people often tend to get bored. Only if you can space out the matches well can you promote the game better.

Claiming 800 Test wickets is unbelievable in today's time. Do you think your record can be broken?

The records are meant to be broken. But I think if someone breaks this record, it will be the highest ever (and is sure to remain unbroken forever). Test cricket is not going to last for long. If you want to take 800 wickets in the format, you need to play at least 150 Tests. I was lucky enough to achieve the feat in 133 outings; hence, in the current scenario, it would be very difficult for players to feature in 150 Tests. Even featuring in 100 Tests will be tough going forward.

Players of this generation — Virat Kohli, Ben Stokes, or R. Ashwin — have been able to feature in more than 100 outings, but for the next generation, there will be a huge question mark on whether they will be able to even come close to that.

In 1996, Sri Lanka changed the dynamics of ODI cricket under the leadership of Arjuna Ranatunga...

Back then, there were a few rule changes in terms of the PowerPlay, and I think much before (Sanath)

Jayasuriya and Kalu (Romesh Kaluwitharana) dominated the scene, New Zealand upped its ante during the 1992 World Cup with some power-hitting by Dipak Patel and Mark Greatbatch.

In the 1996 World Cup, Arjuna got in young people and wanted to experiment with a few things. His idea was simple: he told the batters to go out and play aggressively. It was okay; if they lost their wicket, there were others to back them up. That changed the dimensions of PowerPlay.

Nowadays, if you do something different, people like it, and we must enjoy whatever they call it (laughs).

Is there any current captain who reminds you of a Ranatunga?

There are very good captains, but you also need to see whether they are doing what Arjuna did for me in those turbulent times [between 1995 and 1999, as Muralitharan's 'chucking' row boiled, Ranatunga backed the then-young spinner]. But there are a lot of aggressive captains today. Virat Kohli was a very aggressive captain on the field. He always wanted results.

Over the last few years, the Sri Lankan team seems to be struggling. According to you, where does the team go from here?

Sri Lanka cricket, I think, is in good hands because there are competitions; we have an IPL-like tournament, the Premier League. So, the encouragement is there.

Even the schools play cricket

regularly and produce talent. It depends on the individuals playing the game. Those representing Sri Lanka in international cricket should put in a little more effort. Nowadays, it looks like that is not there. You can't complain as there are all the facilities available and there are good coaches. So, we need to see where we are going wrong.

Your thoughts on being conferred the International Icon and if could tell us who inspired you to pursue cricket?

I am the first one to be conferred with Sportstar's International Icon award and I feel lucky. My sincere gratitude to Sportstar, The Hindu Group and the jury comprising legends.

In my school days, I was in a hostel and cricket was something that everyone loved because our neighbouring country, India, was already a powerhouse in the game and we would follow them. Back then, we only wanted to watch the Indian cricketers. The first time I went to watch a match was in 1985 when the legends Sunil Gavaskar and Kapil Dev featured in a Test against Sri Lanka at the Asgiriya Stadium in Kandy.

It was inspiring to watch them on the field, because back in those days, there was no television.

As our island nation went into huge problems around that time, sports was one thing that gave joy to all youngsters, and it made us forget other things. That inspired me to take up sport and that is why I am here now.



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